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LEARNER GUIDE

For

Mastering Service Branding Strategies to Grow Your Business

Course Code: C233

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How to Use This Guide

Read the concept section before each activity, then complete the activity in its individual folder. Detailed procedures belong here and in the activity Markdown files; the slide deck remains visual and concept-led.

Evidence boundary: Each activity uses a documented real event as context. All organisation details, metrics and operational inputs not in the cited source are explicitly fictional training assumptions.

Course Learning Outcomes

- LO1: Explain how a service brand creates business impact, trust, differentiation and customer value.
- LO2: Apply an organisation's brand strategy to service promises, touchpoints and competitive advantage.
- LO3: Champion service-brand adoption through employees, communication, experience design and recovery.
- LO4: Evaluate service-brand impact using customer, employee, operational and commercial evidence.

The Real-Event Activity Portfolio

Activities 1–8 use public evidence from Babylist, DBS, Ritz-Carlton, Starbucks, Zappos, Airbnb, Singapore Airlines and BOP Design. Every activity is self-contained and distinguishes sourced facts from simulated workplace data.

1. Babylist: Make an Intangible Service Easy to Trust — primary case source

2. DBS: Translate 'Live more, Bank less' into Business Value — primary case source

3. Ritz-Carlton: Promise-to-Proof Service Blueprint — primary case source

4. Starbucks: Redesign the Third-Place Journey — primary case source

5. Zappos: Build an Internal Brand Adoption System — primary case source

6. Airbnb: Recover Trust Across a Service Ecosystem — primary case source

7. Singapore Airlines: Design a Balanced Brand-Impact Scorecard — primary case source

8. BOP Design: Evaluate a Human B2B Brand in an AI-Saturated Market — primary case source

Topic 1 — Service Brand Value and Business Impact

Focus: Intangibility · trust · risk reduction · differentiation · commercial value.

Key Concepts

- Promise: A service brand sets an expectation about the outcome and treatment customers should receive.
- Experience: Customers interpret the brand through people, processes, physical and digital evidence.
- Trust: Consistent proof lowers perceived risk before an intangible service can be evaluated.

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- Value: A strong service brand can support preference, loyalty, referrals, resilience and price confidence.

A service brand is a promise made visible through experience.

Key point: A service brand is a promise made visible through experience. Identity attracts attention; repeated delivery earns belief.

Why services need a different branding lens

- Intangible: Customers cannot inspect the full service before buying; cues and proof reduce uncertainty.
- Inseparable: Employees and customers often co-produce the experience in real time.
- Variable: Performance can change across people, channels, locations and moments.
- Perishable: Unused capacity cannot be stored; demand and access shape the experience.

Value is co-created, not merely exchanged

The product era · goods-dominant logic

- Goods-dominant logic: value is built into the offering and realised at the point of sale.
- The customer is a passive recipient of what was produced.
- Attention sits on value-in-exchange — the price paid.

The service era · service-dominant logic

- Service-dominant logic: value is intangible and created with the customer in real time.
- The customer is an active partner in producing the outcome.
- Attention sits on value-in-use — the benefit actually realised.

Perceived risk rises as tangibility falls

A continuum running from “Easy to evaluate · lower risk” to “Hard to evaluate · higher risk”.

- Search qualities: Can be judged before purchase by direct inspection, such as a room, a menu or a device.
- Experience qualities: Can be judged only after use, such as a meal, a stay, a course or a consultation.
- Credence qualities: Hard to judge even after use because the customer lacks the expertise, such as legal, medical or advisory work.

Why it matters: As an offer moves toward credence, customers lean on risk relievers instead of inspection: standards, guarantees, credentials and brand reputation. That is the work a service brand does.

How service-brand value is created

1. Clear promise
2. Credible signals
3. Consistent delivery
4. Positive memory
5. Trust and advocacy

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Benefits across the business

- Customer: Faster recognition, lower perceived risk and clearer reasons to choose.
- Employee: Shared standards and meaning guide judgement at moments that matter.
- Commercial: Preference, retention, referrals and premium confidence can strengthen economics.
- Strategic: A coherent brand focuses investment and makes expansion easier to govern.

Brand identity and brand meaning

Perspective A

- Identity is what the organisation intends: name, promise, voice, design and standards.
- Management can define and communicate these signals.
- They create expectations before service use.

Perspective B

- Meaning is what customers and employees conclude from lived experience.
- It is shaped by outcomes, emotions, stories and recovery.
- It cannot be declared into existence.

Each service characteristic sets a branding task

- Intangibility → evidence: Cannot be touched or inspected, so supply physical and peripheral cues that stand in for inspection.
- Inseparability → interaction: Produced and consumed at the same moment, so manage the customer–employee encounter directly.
- Perishability → capacity: Cannot be stored, so match supply to demand through scheduling, access and pricing.
- Variability → standards: Quality depends on human actors, so standardise the core process and invest in frontline capability.

Sell the capability, not the component

What the evidence shows

- The object is a distribution mechanism; the customer buys the outcome it enables.
- A streaming service sells discovery and access, not ownership of recordings.
- A sportswear brand sells athletic progress through apps, community and tracking, not only footwear.

What it means for your brand

- Ask what capability the customer gains, not what the organisation hands over.
- Define the promise around the realised benefit so it survives changes in the delivery mechanism.
- Value emerges across an ecosystem of customers, employees, partners and digital tools.

Three forms of service-brand proof

- Performance: Reliable outcomes, accuracy, timeliness and problem resolution.
- People: Competence, empathy, judgement and confidence in the promise.
- Evidence: Environment, content, reviews, cases, process visibility and guarantees.

The 7Ps as brand-delivery levers

- Proposition: Product/service, price and promotion frame the value and expectation.

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- Access: Place and channel determine convenience, inclusion and reach.
- Delivery: People and process convert the promise into customer outcomes.
- Proof: Physical evidence and digital cues make quality easier to judge.

Customer decision journey

1. Recognise need
2. Search
3. Compare
4. Commit
5. Experience
6. Remember and share

Sources of perceived risk

- Functional: Will it solve the problem?
- Financial: Is the outcome worth the price?
- Time: Will access or delay create loss?
- Social: What will the choice signal to others?

Competitive advantage versus empty claims

Perspective A

- Distinctive promise tied to a valued customer outcome.
- Capabilities and standards competitors cannot easily copy.
- Evidence from consistent delivery and recovery.

Perspective B

- Generic superlatives such as best, trusted or world-class.
- Visual refresh without operational change.
- A promise employees cannot explain or deliver.

Brand value chain

- Input: Strategy, research, talent, systems and service design.
- Delivery: Touchpoint performance, employee behaviour and recovery.
- Response: Awareness, trust, satisfaction, preference and advocacy.
- Outcome: Retention, referral, revenue quality and strategic resilience.

Differentiation must be experienced, not merely described.

Key point: Differentiation must be experienced, not merely described. The test is whether customers can name the difference and employees can reproduce it.

Activity 1 — Babylist: Make an Intangible Service Easy to Trust

Focus: Explain the business impact and benefits of tangible service-brand proof.

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Goal and Deliverable

Use Shopify's Babylist example to diagnose how a service brand reduces risk and creates a clear reason to choose.

- Deliverable: One-page service-brand value map and prioritised proof plan

Real-World Scenario

Shopify presents Babylist as a service-brand example and describes service branding as building a recognisable identity and experience around an intangible offering.

A Singapore family-services platform combines consultations, curated recommendations and digital planning tools. Growth has slowed because prospects cannot see why the service is more valuable than free online advice.

Source: https://www.shopify.com/sg/blog/service-branding

Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The Singapore platform, customer interviews and commercial figures are fictional training inputs, not Babylist disclosures.
- Mock research shows first-time parents value reassurance, time saved and unbiased recommendations.
- The current landing page leads with features and has no process map, expert proof or outcome story.
- Management will fund one 90-day proof-building initiative before changing price.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: Which functional, financial, time and social risks affect the customer's decision?

Question 2: What brand benefits could matter to customers, employees and the business?

Question 3: Which three tangible cues would make the promise easier to trust?

Question 4: What is the defensible competitive advantage, and what evidence is still missing?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Separate facts and assumptions

Read the source excerpt and label every statement about Babylist, the fictional platform and customer evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Define customer progress

Write the customer's job, pains, desired gains and purchase risk in one concise problem statement.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Map brand impact

Connect a clear promise to credible proof, customer response and commercial outcome without claiming unsupported causality.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

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Step 4 — Inventory existing cues

Score process visibility, expert evidence, outcome stories, reviews, assurance and service recovery from 1 to 5.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Design proof

Select three cues and specify content, owner, touchpoint and the uncertainty each cue reduces.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — State the advantage

Write one relevant, distinctive and deliverable competitive-advantage statement plus the evidence needed to validate it.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The submission separates facts from assumptions, links at least three proof cues to customer risk and business benefit, and states a defensible advantage with validation evidence.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Activity 2 — DBS: Translate 'Live more, Bank less' into Business Value

Focus: Demonstrate appreciation of a service brand and its competitive advantage.

Goal and Deliverable

Use DBS's public brand promise to trace how a promise can influence customer experience and business outcomes.

- Deliverable: Promise-to-impact logic model and 250-word management narrative

Real-World Scenario

DBS states that its brand promise is 'Live more, Bank less' and describes making banking simple and effortless so customers can spend more time on what matters.

A regional business bank wants to learn from the logic of DBS's promise without copying its words. The bank must identify a customer outcome it can credibly own and show how delivery would create value.

Source: https://www.dbs.com/about-us/who-we-are/our-promise-to-you

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Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The regional bank and performance data are fictional; no DBS operating metrics are supplied or inferred.
- Small-business customers report repeated-document requests, slow onboarding and unclear case ownership.
- Management defines success as lower customer effort and faster time to first value, subject to compliance controls.
- The team may redesign one journey but cannot replace the core banking platform this quarter.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: What customer outcome makes the DBS promise relevant rather than merely memorable?

Question 2: Which service capabilities would be required to make a comparable promise credible?

Question 3: How could improved delivery affect trust, retention, referral and cost-to-serve?

Question 4: Which alternative explanations must be considered before claiming business impact?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Interpret the promise

Identify the audience, desired progress, emotional benefit and implied service standard in the public DBS statement.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Diagnose the fictional journey

Map onboarding friction, customer effort, handoffs, delays and moments of uncertainty.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Choose a differentiated outcome

Write an original promise for the regional bank that is relevant, distinctive and operationally deliverable.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 4 — Build the logic model

Connect capabilities to service behaviours, customer responses and commercial outcomes; mark each link as hypothesis or evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Stress-test credibility

Identify compliance, technology, channel and employee constraints that could break the promise.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Draft the management narrative

Explain the competitive advantage, expected benefits, risk, first experiment and evidence threshold for scaling.

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Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The logic model contains capability, delivery, customer and business layers; every causal claim is labelled; and the proposed promise is original, relevant and deliverable.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Topic 2 — From Brand Strategy to Service Experience

Focus: Purpose · audience · positioning · promise · touchpoints · tangible cues.

Key Concepts

- Purpose: Clarifies the valued outcome and role the organisation chooses to play.
- Positioning: Defines the audience, frame of reference, relevant difference and proof.
- Promise: Turns positioning into an expectation that can be translated into service standards.
- Touchpoints: Connect strategy to the moments before, during and after service delivery.

Service-brand strategy sequence

1. Research audience
2. Audit market
3. Choose position
4. Write promise
5. Design proof
6. Govern delivery

Audience insight

- Jobs: What progress is the customer trying to make?
- Pains: What risk, effort or uncertainty blocks progress?
- Gains: What outcome and feeling define success?
- Context: Who influences choice, use and renewal?

Positioning choices

Perspective A

- Choose a specific priority audience and decision context.
- Name the valued difference and trade-off.
- Identify capabilities that make the claim credible.

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Perspective B

- Trying to appeal equally to everyone weakens relevance.
- Copying category language creates sameness.
- A promise without operational proof raises disappointment risk.

A practical brand promise

- Relevant: Connects to a meaningful customer outcome.
- Distinctive: Creates a recognisable reason to choose.
- Deliverable: Can be translated into behaviours, process and evidence.

Promise-to-proof architecture

1. Promise
2. Principles
3. Service standards
4. Touchpoint cues
5. Evidence
6. Review

Tangibilise the intangible

- Show process: Explain stages, timelines, owners and what happens next.
- Show expertise: Use credentials, cases, demonstrations and useful content.
- Show outcomes: Use specific evidence and customer stories with context.
- Show assurance: Set expectations, safeguards, access and recovery commitments.

The service expansion of the marketing mix

- Base layer: Product, price, place and promotion frame the offer but cannot by themselves carry an intangible promise.
- People: The human actors who deliver the promise in real time and shape how it is remembered.
- Process: Operational flow, waiting, sequencing and how much the customer is asked to do.
- Physical evidence: The tangible and peripheral cues that signal the quality of something invisible.

Physical space works as a behavioural stimulus

1. Ambient conditions
2. Space and function
3. Signs and symbols
4. Internal response
5. Approach or avoid

Designing the servicescape

Stimulus · the environment

- Stimulus: ambient conditions, layout and equipment, signage, décor and brand livery.
- These cues act on customers and employees at the same time.
- They are read before anyone speaks, so they set the expectation the service must then meet.

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Response · the behaviour

- Response: approach behaviour means explore, stay longer, engage and return.
- Avoidance behaviour means disengage, leave early and discount the promise.
- Digital environments carry the same load — layout, speed, clarity and tone are servicescape too.

Service delivery as a staged performance

Front stage · visible

- Front stage is everything the customer can see: the setting, the interaction and the visible sequence.
- Frontline employees perform the promise, often doing emotional labour to hold it steady.
- The line of visibility marks where customer experience ends and operational mechanics begin.

Back stage · invisible

- Back stage is the support work, systems, training and management that make the front stage possible.
- Customers judge the front stage but failures usually originate behind the line.
- Blueprint both sides to find friction and fail points before customers do.

Map moments that matter

- Before: Discovery, search, enquiry, comparison and booking.
- During: Welcome, diagnosis, delivery, waiting, handoff and payment.
- After: Onboarding, follow-up, support, renewal and advocacy.
- Failure: Recognition, ownership, recovery and learning.

Standardise and personalise

Perspective A

- Standardise non-negotiable outcomes, safety, accuracy and brand-critical cues.
- Make handoffs and exception ownership visible.
- Measure whether the minimum promise is delivered.

Perspective B

- Personalise language, recommendation, pace and support to customer context.
- Give employees bounded judgement, not unlimited discretion.
- Protect privacy and fairness when data drives personalisation.

Service blueprint layers

1. Customer action
2. Frontstage interaction
3. Backstage work
4. Support process
5. Evidence and metric

Consistency without sameness

- Outcome: The core benefit remains dependable.
- Character: The brand feels recognisable across channels.

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- Context: Delivery adapts to channel and customer need.
- Control: Exceptions are owned, logged and learned from.

Relationship-building mechanisms

- Access: Make expert help easy to reach.
- Continuity: Remember context and reduce repeated effort.
- Reciprocity: Create useful exchanges beyond the transaction.

Strategy becomes real at the next customer touchpoint.

Key point: Strategy becomes real at the next customer touchpoint. If the promise cannot guide a design or operating decision, it is still too vague.

Activity 3 — Ritz-Carlton: Promise-to-Proof Service Blueprint

Focus: Apply organisation branding strategy to service standards and touchpoints.

Goal and Deliverable

Use the Ritz-Carlton Gold Standards as a public reference for translating brand intent into observable delivery.

- Deliverable: Promise-to-proof architecture and service blueprint for four moments that matter

Real-World Scenario

Ritz-Carlton publicly presents its Gold Standards—including its credo, motto and service values—as the foundation of its service culture.

A Singapore premium eldercare concierge has a warm visual identity but inconsistent enquiry, onboarding and family-update experiences. It wants standards that feel personal rather than scripted.

Source: https://www.ritzcarlton.com/en/services/standards/

Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The eldercare concierge, personas and operational data are fictional and are not connected to Ritz-Carlton.
- Families value dignity, clarity, continuity and rapid escalation when care needs change.
- The organisation has 12 advisors across phone, WhatsApp and in-person channels.
- Privacy, safeguarding and clinical escalation are non-negotiable guardrails.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: What strategic promise should the concierge make, and to whom?

Question 2: Which service principles and observable standards would make the promise real?

Question 3: Where should delivery be standardised, and where should employees exercise judgement?

Question 4: What physical or digital evidence would reassure families before and during service?

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Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Extract the pattern

Study how the public Gold Standards connect purpose, values and service behaviour; do not copy protected brand language.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Define positioning

Specify priority audience, frame of reference, valued difference and proof for the fictional concierge.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Write the promise

Create a concise, relevant and deliverable promise, then translate it into three service principles.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 4 — Map the journey

Select enquiry, onboarding, first week and exception handling as moments that matter.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Build the blueprint

For each moment, document customer action, frontstage behaviour, backstage support, tangible evidence and metric.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Set guardrails

Define non-negotiable outcomes, bounded personalisation, escalation triggers, owner and evidence of completion.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The blueprint traces one promise through principles, observable standards, backstage enablers, tangible cues and measures, with explicit privacy and safeguarding guardrails.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Activity 4 — Starbucks: Redesign the Third-Place Journey

Focus: Use a service-brand strategy to differentiate a real customer journey.

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Goal and Deliverable

Use Starbucks's public mission as a lens for aligning positioning, environment, people and process across a service journey.

- Deliverable: Current/future journey map and three-minute differentiated service concept pitch

Real-World Scenario

Starbucks states a mission centred on coffee, the human spirit, connection and belonging, expressed through person, cup and neighbourhood.

An independent Singapore neighbourhood café is losing customers to delivery apps and chain competitors. It wants to become the preferred place for quiet weekday connection without imitating Starbucks.

Source: https://about.starbucks.com/mission/

Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The café, customer data, budget and constraints are fictional training inputs.
- Its priority segment is hybrid workers and nearby residents seeking calm, reliable social connection.
- The café can adjust layout, booking, host behaviour, menu presentation and community programming.
- Any concept must maintain seat turnover and accessibility rather than maximise dwell time alone.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: What customer job and emotional outcome should define the café's position?

Question 2: Which 7Ps currently contradict the intended brand experience?

Question 3: Which three moments could become distinctive and difficult to copy?

Question 4: How will the team balance belonging, accessibility and commercial viability?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Read the public mission

Identify the human outcome, community context and delivery implications without adopting Starbucks language.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Choose the audience

Define the priority segment, occasion, alternatives, unmet need and reason the café can credibly serve it.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Map the current journey

Document discovery, arrival, ordering, stay, departure and return, including effort, emotion and evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

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Step 4 — Audit the 7Ps

Score service proposition, price, access, communication, people, process and physical evidence for strategic alignment.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Design three signature moments

Specify the cue, employee behaviour, operating process and customer outcome for each moment.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Test the concept

Evaluate distinctiveness, relevance, deliverability, accessibility and unit-economics risk; revise the pitch.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The future journey targets a defined audience, aligns all 7Ps, contains three signature moments with operational enablers, and addresses accessibility and viability trade-offs.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Topic 3 — Champion Adoption and Deliver the Promise

Focus: Internal branding · leadership · employee enablement · culture · recovery.

Key Concepts

- Internal brand: Employees need shared meaning, capability and reinforcement—not slogans alone.
- Leadership: What leaders fund, model, recognise and correct signals the true brand.
- Enablement: Training, tools, decision rights and feedback turn intent into repeatable action.
- Recovery: A well-owned failure can restore confidence and reveal where the system must improve.

Internal brand adoption

1. Understand
2. Believe
3. Know how
4. Have authority
5. Act

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6. Learn and reinforce

Employee brand alignment

- Meaning: Explain who the service is for and why the promise matters.
- Role: Show how each function affects the customer outcome.
- Capability: Practise the behaviours and judgement required.
- Reinforcement: Align measures, recognition, coaching and consequences.

Internal communication and internal branding

Perspective A

- Communication distributes messages and information.
- Awareness is necessary but not sufficient.
- Campaigns fade if systems reward different behaviour.

Perspective B

- Internal branding aligns culture, capability and operations with the promise.
- Employees test the promise against daily reality.
- Leaders must resolve contradictions.

In a co-created service, the employee is the brand.

Key point: In a co-created service, the employee is the brand. The gap that damages brands is between the promise marketing makes and the delivery employees execute at the moment of truth.

Five inputs that build brand commitment

- Internal communication: Top-down clarity about the promise combined with bottom-up feedback that is actually used.
- Market information: Exposing staff to real customer feedback and competitor behaviour, not filtered summaries.
- Brand training: Moving past generic service skills to teach the brand-specific behaviours this promise requires.
- Brand leadership: Managers acting as visible role models, especially when the promise is costly to keep.

Knowledge alone does not produce performance

- Brand knowledge (Cognitive): I know what the brand stands for. Necessary, but on its own it changes nothing.
- Brand commitment (Psychological bond): I believe in the brand and want it to succeed — an emotional attachment, not just compliance.
- Brand performance (Behavioural output): I deliver the promise consistently at the moment of truth, including when it is inconvenient.

Leader actions that build credibility

- Model: Use the language and standards in real decisions.
- Enable: Remove barriers and fund brand-critical capabilities.
- Reinforce: Recognise evidence and address promise-breaking behaviour.

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Brand champion network

- Sponsor: Owns strategic commitment and cross-functional barriers.
- Champions: Translate the promise into local context and collect feedback.
- Managers: Coach performance and manage exceptions.
- Employees: Deliver, observe, recover and improve the experience.

Behaviour design

1. Critical moment
2. Desired customer feeling
3. Observable behaviour
4. Tool or standard
5. Evidence
6. Coaching

Empowerment guardrails

- Purpose: The outcome employees should protect.
- Limits: Safety, privacy, legal and financial boundaries.
- Authority: Decisions and resources available without escalation.
- Escalation: Clear route when needs exceed authority.

Storytelling with integrity

Perspective A

- Use specific customer and employee moments.
- Connect the action to the promise and outcome.
- Include tension, judgement and evidence.

Perspective B

- Avoid invented testimonials or unsupported hero stories.
- Do not turn systemic failures into individual blame.
- Protect confidentiality and consent.

Service-recovery loop

1. Recognise
2. Own
3. Stabilise
4. Resolve
5. Restore confidence
6. Learn

Recovery dimensions

- Outcome fairness: A reasonable fix, replacement or remedy.
- Process fairness: Low effort, timely handling and clear ownership.
- Interaction fairness: Respect, empathy and credible explanation.

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- Learning: Cause, action owner and prevention evidence.

Adoption evidence

- Leading: Training completion, confidence, tool use and coaching.
- Behaviour: Observed standards, handoff quality and recovery ownership.
- Outcome: Customer experience, rework, retention and referrals.

Employees cannot deliver a promise the organisation does not enable.

Key point: Employees cannot deliver a promise the organisation does not enable. Internal branding is the operating system behind the external claim.

Activity 5 — Zappos: Build an Internal Brand Adoption System

Focus: Champion adoption of the service brand through culture and employee enablement.

Goal and Deliverable

Use Zappos's public culture materials to design an adoption system that aligns meaning, capability and reinforcement.

- Deliverable: Internal-brand adoption charter and 30-day activation sprint

Real-World Scenario

Zappos Insights publicly describes a culture shaped by core values and employee behaviours, and offers culture-focused learning based on the company's experience.

A Singapore home-services marketplace has launched the promise 'Care you can count on', but customer support, operations and field partners interpret it differently.

Source: https://www.zapposinsights.com/about/culture

Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The marketplace, interview statements and performance data are fictional and not Zappos information.
- Employees understand the words but lack examples, authority and aligned performance measures.
- Field partners are contractors; adoption must include onboarding and quality governance.
- The sponsor can change coaching, recognition and escalation rules within 30 days.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: What must employees understand, believe, know and be able to do?

Question 2: Which three behaviours best express dependable care at critical moments?

Question 3: What systems currently contradict the promise?

Question 4: How should champions, managers and leaders reinforce adoption?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Diagnose the adoption gap

Sort evidence into meaning, belief, capability, authority and reinforcement gaps by role.

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Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Define critical moments

Select booking, arrival, work completion and complaint handling; describe the desired customer outcome.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Specify behaviours

Write observable behaviours, tools, boundaries and escalation paths for each critical moment.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 4 — Design the champion network

Assign sponsor, cross-functional champions, managers and partner leads with explicit responsibilities.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Align reinforcement

Change one coaching ritual, one recognition mechanism and one metric that currently rewards the wrong behaviour.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Plan the sprint

Sequence communication, practice, manager coaching, field observation and feedback across 30 days.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The plan names role-specific behaviours, tools and guardrails; assigns sponsor/champion/manager ownership; and includes leading, behavioural and outcome evidence.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Activity 6 — Airbnb: Recover Trust Across a Service Ecosystem

Focus: Champion the service brand during failure and recovery.

Goal and Deliverable

Use Airbnb's public description of its community marketplace to design brand-consistent recovery across customer, provider and platform roles.

- Deliverable: Service-recovery playbook with authority matrix and three customer messages

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Real-World Scenario

Airbnb describes itself as a community built around connection, enabled by hosts offering stays and experiences to guests through its platform.

A Singapore experience-booking platform faces a same-day provider cancellation that disrupts a family's celebration. The platform, provider and payment partner must coordinate recovery.

Source: https://news.airbnb.com/about-us/

Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The booking platform, incident, family and financial amounts are fictional and not an Airbnb event.
- The booking value is S$480 and an alternative provider is available at S$620 two hours later.
- Frontline agents may approve S$150 without escalation; safety and fraud flags require specialist review.
- The promise is 'Local moments, made dependable'.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: What outcome, process and interaction fairness does the customer need?

Question 2: Who owns the recovery when value is co-created by several parties?

Question 3: What authority and guardrails should frontline employees have?

Question 4: What evidence would show confidence is restored and the system improved?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Map the ecosystem

Identify customer, provider, platform, payment partner and support roles, dependencies and decision rights.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Define the recovery objective

State the practical outcome, emotional need, time constraint and non-negotiable safeguards.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Run the recovery loop

Design recognition, ownership, stabilisation, resolution, confidence restoration and learning actions.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 4 — Build the decision matrix

Set frontline authority, escalation thresholds, remedy options and communication cadence for four incident levels.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Draft communications

Write first acknowledgement, progress update and closure message using verified facts and respectful language.

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Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Close the loop

Record root cause, provider action, platform action, owner, due date and verification evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The playbook protects outcome/process/interaction fairness, assigns ecosystem ownership, respects authority limits, and closes with a verified improvement action.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Topic 4 — Evaluate and Improve Service-Brand Impact

Focus: Measurement system · KPI logic · journey evidence · diagnosis · improvement.

Key Concepts

- System: Use a balanced chain of measures rather than one headline score.
- Causality: Connect employee and operational drivers to customer and business outcomes.
- Segmentation: Averages hide differences by journey, channel, audience and recovery status.
- Action: Every measure needs a decision, owner, threshold and review cadence.

Brand-impact measurement chain

1. Capability
2. Delivery behaviour
3. Customer response
4. Commercial outcome
5. Learning

Four measurement lenses

- Customer: Awareness, consideration, trust, effort, satisfaction and advocacy.
- Employee: Understanding, belief, confidence, enablement and observed behaviour.
- Operational: Accuracy, wait, resolution, handoff, recovery and consistency.
- Commercial: Conversion, retention, referral, share of wallet and revenue quality.

Leading and lagging indicators

Perspective A

- Leading: training, confidence, staffing, standard adherence and response time.
- They provide earlier signals and can be influenced directly.

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- They do not prove customer or commercial impact alone.

Perspective B

- Lagging: trust, retention, referrals, complaints and revenue outcomes.
- They confirm accumulated results but arrive later.
- They may be affected by price, seasonality and market conditions.

Common customer measures

- NPS: Relationship or journey advocacy; pair with reasons and behaviour.
- CSAT: Satisfaction with a defined interaction or outcome.
- CES: Effort required to complete a task or resolve an issue.

Qualitative evidence

- Interviews: Explore meaning, trade-offs and unmet needs.
- Observation: See actual behaviour and friction in context.
- Reviews: Detect repeated language, moments and expectations.
- Complaints: Reveal failure patterns, ownership and recovery quality.

Build a useful KPI

1. Decision
2. Metric definition
3. Data source
4. Baseline and target
5. Segment
6. Owner and cadence

Measurement quality checks

- Valid: Represents the construct or outcome claimed.
- Reliable: Produces comparable results under defined conditions.
- Timely: Available before the decision window closes.
- Actionable: Has a clear owner and response threshold.

Correlation and contribution

Perspective A

- Track whether brand-related changes move with experience and business results.
- Use journey and segment comparisons to narrow explanations.
- State uncertainty and alternative drivers.

Perspective B

- Avoid claiming one campaign caused all commercial change.
- Use experiments, phased rollout or matched comparison where feasible.
- Triangulate quantitative and qualitative evidence.

Dashboard design

- Promise: The customer outcome the dashboard tests.

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- Signal: A small set of driver and outcome measures.
- Context: Target, trend, segment and notable change.
- Action: Owner, decision, due date and expected effect.

Insight-to-improvement cycle

1. Detect
2. Diagnose
3. Prioritise
4. Experiment
5. Verify
6. Standardise or stop

Evaluation cadences

- Operational: Daily or weekly exceptions and recovery.
- Journey: Monthly performance and qualitative themes.
- Strategic: Quarterly position, portfolio and investment choices.

The architecture of value actualisation

Three reinforcing nodes producing seamless service performance — The output

- The philosophy — Service-dominant logic: Shift focus from selling objects to co-creating value-in-use with the customer.
- The engine — Internal branding: Align, equip and empower the people who deliver the promise.
- The stage — Servicescape and process: Design the physical, digital and operational environment that guides behaviour.

Four strategic imperatives for an intangible economy

- Sell outcomes, not objects: Define the proposition around the capability enabled, not the item distributed.
- Blueprint the theatre: Map front-stage interaction and back-stage process to remove friction and locate fail points.
- Use the environment: Treat physical and digital space as a signal of quality that shapes what customers do.
- Build from the inside out: Fund internal capability as seriously as external marketing; employees are the brand asset.

A metric is useful only when it changes a decision.

Key point: A metric is useful only when it changes a decision. Measure the promise, diagnose the experience and close the improvement loop.

Activity 7 — Singapore Airlines: Design a Balanced Brand-Impact Scorecard

Focus: Evaluate service-brand impact using balanced evidence.

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Goal and Deliverable

Use Singapore Airlines's public service story as the context for a scorecard that connects employee capability, delivery and customer outcomes.

- Deliverable: Eight-metric brand-impact scorecard, KPI dictionary and review agenda

Real-World Scenario

Singapore Airlines publicly describes a longstanding focus on service excellence, innovation and the Singapore Girl as part of its brand story.

A fictional premium regional airline wants to test whether its 'Thoughtful journeys, every time' promise is being delivered consistently across booking, airport, cabin and disruption recovery.

Source: https://www.singaporeair.com/en_UK/us/about-us/our-story/

Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The airline, promise and dataset are fictional and must not be attributed to Singapore Airlines.
- The mock data includes employee confidence, departure communication, first-contact resolution, effort, satisfaction, complaints and repeat booking.
- The dashboard has space for eight measures and must support a monthly management decision.
- Safety and regulatory measures remain separate hard constraints and cannot be traded for experience scores.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: Which leading and lagging measures best test the promise?

Question 2: How should results be segmented to expose inconsistency?

Question 3: Which metric definitions or data sources could mislead management?

Question 4: What threshold should trigger action, and who owns the response?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Define the decision

State the monthly management decision the scorecard must support and the promise outcome being tested.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Build the measurement chain

Connect capability, delivery behaviour, customer response and commercial outcome; identify assumptions.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Select eight measures

Choose a balanced mix of employee, operational, customer and commercial indicators with leading and lagging coverage.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

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Step 4 — Write KPI definitions

For each measure specify formula, population, source, cadence, owner, target, threshold and limitation.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Analyse mock data

Calculate trends and segment by journey stage, channel and disruption status; identify material differences.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Create the action review

Prioritise one issue, name the decision, owner, due date, expected effect and verification measure.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Acceptance Test

Pass condition: Every KPI has a decision, definition, source, owner and threshold; the set balances four evidence lenses; and the analysis identifies a segment-level action without unsupported causal claims.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

Activity 8 — BOP Design: Evaluate a Human B2B Brand in an AI-Saturated Market

Focus: Evaluate current service-brand impact and recommend an evidence-based improvement.

Goal and Deliverable

Use BOP Design's 2026–2027 trend perspective to build an evaluation plan for a real B2B professional-service context.

- Deliverable: Brand evaluation report and one-page 90-day experiment brief

Real-World Scenario

BOP Design argues that B2B brands in 2026–2027 need coherent systems, human relevance, strategic AI use, clearer data communication and consistency across machine- and human-mediated discovery.

A Singapore cybersecurity advisory firm has adopted AI-assisted content and lead qualification. Enquiry volume rose, but prospects say the firm feels generic and are less certain whom they will work with.

Source: https://www.bopdesign.com/bop-blog/b2b-branding-trends-for-2026-and-2027/

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Training Assumptions and Guardrails

- The advisory firm, research quotes and funnel data are fictional training inputs, not BOP Design client results.
- The team can run interviews, analyse search/enquiry data and test one website/service-introduction change over 90 days.
- The firm promises 'Clear decisions in complex cyber risk'.
- AI use must preserve confidentiality, accuracy, disclosure and expert accountability.

Scenario Questions

Question 1: Which evidence would distinguish awareness growth from stronger brand preference?

Question 2: How can the firm test whether generic AI-mediated content weakened trust?

Question 3: What human and system cues should be evaluated across the buyer journey?

Question 4: Which 90-day experiment offers the clearest learning at acceptable risk?

Detailed Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — Frame the evaluation

Define the promise, audience, decision, hypotheses and alternative explanations.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Build the evidence matrix

Combine interviews, journey observation, content/search data, sales feedback, conversion and retention evidence.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 3 — Audit measurement quality

Check validity, reliability, timeliness, sample bias, attribution limits and privacy for each source.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 4 — Analyse the journey

Compare discovery, evaluation, consultation and proposal stages; segment AI-assisted and expert-led touchpoints.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 5 — Diagnose the gap

Identify whether the main issue is relevance, distinctiveness, credibility, consistency or delivery.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

Step 6 — Design the experiment

Specify change, audience, comparison, success measures, guardrails, owner and stop/scale decision after 90 days.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced before moving to the next step.

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Acceptance Test

Pass condition: The evaluation triangulates at least three evidence types, states limitations and alternative explanations, and defines an ethical experiment with success, guardrail and stop/scale criteria.

Reflection and Debrief

1. Which customer or employee insight changed your recommendation most, and why?
2. What additional evidence would you request?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next service-brand decision?
4. What should the organisation start, stop or continue?

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Zappos Insights — Culture: https://www.zapposinsights.com/about/culture

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Airbnb — About us: https://news.airbnb.com/about-us/

Glossary

- Brand promise: The customer outcome and experience an organisation commits to deliver.
- Positioning: The relevant and distinctive place a brand seeks to occupy for a chosen audience.
- Touchpoint: Any interaction or cue through which a stakeholder experiences the brand.
- Service blueprint: A map linking customer actions, frontstage interactions, backstage work, support and evidence.
- Internal branding: Alignment of employees, culture, capability and systems with the external promise.
- NPS: Net Promoter Score, an advocacy measure interpreted with reasons and behaviour.
- CSAT: Customer satisfaction with a defined interaction or outcome.
- CES: Customer effort required to complete a task or resolve an issue.
- Leading indicator: An earlier driver signal that can be influenced before final results are known.
- Lagging indicator: A result measure confirming accumulated outcomes after delivery.

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